Men on both sides fought with the utmost courage amid the indescribable carnage of the battle.

In the attempt to cross the line, *Victory* became entangled with the 74-gun *Redoutable*, commanded by the able Captain Jean-Jacques Lucas. *Redoutable*'s rigging was swarming with infantry armed with muskets and grenades, intent on clearing *Victory*'s upper decks preparatory to boarding. At about 1:15 p.m. a musket ball struck Nelson, who was standing in full view on the quarterdeck, overseeing the battle. It passed down through his shoulder and lodged alongside his spine. He was carried below, where he would die more than three hours later. *Victory* was saved from being taken by the arrival of the 98-gun *Temeraire*, which hit *Redoutable* with a broadside that killed or wounded some 200 men. *Temeraire* then drifted into *Redoutable*, while disabling *Fougueux* with a broadside from its disengaged side. Both *Redoutable* and *Fougueux* struck their colors to *Temeraire*. A similar pattern of hard-fought combat and eventual surrender was being played out everywhere in the French-Spanish center and rear. Some of the first British ships to engage took severe punishment. *Belleisle*, which followed *Royal Sovereign*, was engaged at different times by seven French and Spanish ships and left as a dismasted hulk with 126 men dead or wounded. The captain of *Mars*, George Duff, had his head struck off by a cannonball, one of 300 casualties the ship suffered. But the French and Spanish were overwhelmed as fresh British ships came up. *Santa Anna* struck to *Royal Sovereign* after an engagement that also left Collingwood's flagship disabled. The Spanish giant *Santisima Trinidad* surrendered after losing all her masts. Although barely able to fight from the moment it was raked by *Victory*, *Bucentaure* held out for three hours before Villeneuve struck his colors. Amid the slaughter, the surrenders were conducted with dignity and exchange of compliments.



Spanish shot
This iron cannonball was found embedded in *Victory*'s bow. It was fired from a Spanish 40-pounder, the heaviest cannon used at Trafalgar.

Meanwhile 10 ships in the French-Spanish van had been left out of the fight, as Nelson planned. By 2:30 p.m. they had with difficulty maneuvered back against the wind and were approaching the scene of combat. By then seven ships of the combined fleet had already surrendered, but the fighting had left many of the British ships in poor shape. If Dumanoir had led a determined counterattack it might have turned the battle around. But after a half-hearted exchange of fire the French admiral fled southward with four ships. Two other ships from the van were captured by the British, while the rest were among a small band of survivors led by Spanish admiral Gravina back to Cadiz.

Before Nelson died *Victory*'s captain was able to inform him that his final battle had been a triumphant success. Nelson's final words were: "Now I am satisfied. Thank God, I have done my duty." By the end of the day eight French and nine Spanish ships had been captured—more than half the entire fleet. One French ship, the *Achille*, had exploded. No British ships had been lost.

The victory won at the Battle of Trafalgar was a great one for the Royal Navy, establishing as it did a dominance over the world's oceans that would last virtually unchallenged for over a century.

Desperate fight
Marines and gun crews aboard *Victory* fight desperately as the ship is trapped between the French *Bucentaure* and *Redoutable* after crossing the Alied line. Shot by a French sniper on *Redoutable*, Nelson lies mortally wounded on the right.